

ENGLISH LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE – 184

CLASS X

Time Allowed: 3 Hours

Maximum Marks: 80

General Instructions:

1. This question paper contains **11 questions**. All questions are compulsory except where internal choice is provided.
2. The question paper is divided into three sections: **Section A – Reading Skills, Section B – Grammar and Creative Writing Skills, and Section C – Literature Textbook.**
3. Attempt all questions as per the specific instructions given with each question.
4. Where choices are provided, attempt only the required number of questions.
5. Marks are indicated against each question/sub-question.

SECTION A – READING SKILLS

1. Read the following passage carefully and answer the questions that follow. [10]

Saffron, the delicate crimson threads obtained from the flowers of *Crocus sativus*, has been prized for centuries. Its history stretches across ancient civilisations, and references to the spice occur in accounts of trade, medicine, food and ritual. Because the information surrounding saffron can be traced through historical records and observable cultivation practices, a factual account of it is best presented objectively rather than emotionally.

Saffron is often described as the most valuable spice in the world, much as gold is valued among metals. Its value is not merely a matter of prestige. The spice has a distinctive aroma and flavour, and only a small quantity is required to colour and season food. It is revered in many parts of the world because it gives dishes a subtle, earthy sweetness and a characteristic fragrance. It is used in Mediterranean and Asian cuisines and forms part of several well-known dishes, including Spanish rice and paella, French bouillabaisse, Italian risotto, Indian kheer and kulfi, Pakistani biryani, and Iranian baked rice dishes.

The production of saffron is exceptionally labour-intensive. The flowers are harvested carefully, and the three delicate stigmas from each flower are picked by hand. The stigmas are then spread on trays and dried over charcoal fires before being prepared for use as a food-flavouring and colouring agent. The work demands patience and precision, while the yield from each plant is relatively small. These factors contribute greatly to the spice's high price.

Saffron is also vulnerable to adulteration because of its high market value. Beetroot or pomegranate may be used to imitate its red colour; silk fibres, oil or wax may be added to increase bulk; and powdered saffron may be mixed with substances such as turmeric or paprika. For consumers, therefore, the reputation and authenticity of saffron are as important as its culinary appeal.

- (i) Why is the writer being objective and factual while discussing saffron? [1]
- (ii) Why is saffron considered an exceptionally valuable spice? Choose the correct option.
(a) It grows in every climate. (b) It is harvested mechanically. (c) It is highly prized and difficult to produce, making it comparable in value to gold. (d) It is used only for colouring food. [1]
- (iii) Why is saffron revered across the globe? Answer in 30–40 words. [2]
- (iv) Select the option that is closest in meaning to “*recognized*” as used in the passage.
(a) hidden (b) widely known (c) rejected (d) ordinary [1]
- (v) How is saffron processed after the flowers are harvested? Answer briefly. [1]
- (vi) The production of saffron involves handpicking the three stigmas from each flower before drying them. State whether the statement is **True** or **False**. [1]
- (vii) Why does saffron yield a relatively small amount from each plant? Choose the correct option.
(a) It is grown only indoors. (b) It is harvested only once in a decade. (c) Its cultivation and harvesting are highly labour-intensive and yield little per plant. (d) It requires no manual labour. [1]

(viii) Why is saffron commonly adulterated? Mention two or more examples of substances used for adulteration. [2]

2. Read the following passage carefully and answer the questions that follow. [10]

Silk is a natural fibre celebrated for its lustre, softness and strength. The fibre is obtained from the cocoons of silkworms, and the process of producing good-quality silk requires careful attention at every stage. Climate, the availability of suitable mulberry leaves and the time required by the silkworms to complete their life cycle all influence production. The silkworm must feed well and develop under appropriate conditions before the silk filament can be collected.

The process is not a simple one. Healthy silkworms have to be raised and the cocoons collected at the appropriate stage. The silk filament is then carefully extracted, boiled and separated before it can be spun and woven. Because these stages require selection, patience and skilled handling, the production of uniform, superior-quality silk remains labour-intensive. A slight variation in conditions can affect the quality of the final fabric.

Silk is produced in many parts of the world, with China being the leading producer and India following it. Within India, production varies considerably among states. Karnataka has traditionally been an important producer of raw silk, while Uttar Pradesh has produced comparatively smaller quantities. In the productivity comparison referred to here, approximately one kilogram (1 kg) of silk is obtained from the stated quantity of material.

Silk has a reputation for being luxurious. Its smooth texture can make clothing feel comfortable, while its lustrous appearance gives it an expensive look. It can absorb moisture and help regulate body temperature, but it is not completely carefree to maintain. If left dirty, silk may be more easily attacked by insects; when wet it can lose about 20% of its strength, and prolonged exposure to strong sunlight can weaken it. These characteristics make careful storage and handling essential.

(i) Why is silk often described as luxurious? Explain with reference to both its appearance and texture. [1]

(ii) Read the following Assertion (A) and Reason (R).

Assertion (A): The production of high-quality silk is labour-intensive.

Reason (R): The silk filament has to be carefully selected and extracted through several skilled stages.

Choose the correct option:

(a) Both A and R are true and R is the correct explanation of A. (b) Both A and R are true but R is not the correct explanation of A. (c) A is true but R is false. (d) A is false but R is true. [1]

(iii) Why is silk production limited? Answer in 30–40 words. [2]

(iv) China is the _____ producer of silk in the world.

(a) least (b) leading (c) occasional (d) newest [1]

(v) Which country follows China as a major producer of silk according to the passage? [1]

(vi) What happens to silk if it is left dirty, used while wet, or exposed to excessive sunlight? [1]

(vii) Which Indian state is identified as the highest producer of raw silk in the passage? [1]

(viii) How much silk is referred to as being obtained in the productivity comparison? [1]

(ix) Why is sericulture considered labour-intensive? Give two reasons from the passage. [1]

SECTION B – GRAMMAR AND CREATIVE WRITING SKILLS

3. Complete **ANY TEN** of the following twelve tasks, as directed. [10]

(i) Fill in the blank with the correct form of the word given in brackets:

_____ the advantages of the proposal, the committee decided to proceed with it. (consider)

(ii) The following sentence has an error. Identify the error and write the correction:

The teacher was tapping by the principal for her excellent work.

(iii) Rewrite the following in reported speech:

Yuki asked Sanjay, "Does that restaurant serve good South Indian food?"

(iv) Choose the correct option to complete the reported speech:

Riya said that _____ she could manage the assignment alone.

(a) if she was sure (b) if she were sure (c) whether she is sure (d) that she was sure

(v) Fill in the blank with the correct form of the word given in brackets:

Many birds _____ to warmer regions during winter. (migration)

(vi) Identify the error and write the correction:

She did not say much about the incident, but she told us much important.

(vii) Identify the error and write the correction:

There was a strong bond between the members of the team, among the captain and the vice-captain.

(viii) Fill in the blank with the correct form of the word given in brackets:

The children _____ the cultural programme immensely. (enjoy)

(ix) Rewrite in reported speech:

Anita said, "I finished the project yesterday."

(x) Choose the correct option:

The annual cultural festival _____ next Friday.

(a) will held (b) will be held (c) would held (d) has held

(xi) Choose the correct option:

Please _____ that all the documents are attached before submitting the form.

(a) insure (b) ensure (c) assure (d) secure

(xii) Identify the error and write the correction:

The students went upto the auditorium before the programme began.

4. Attempt **ANY ONE** of the following two questions, in about 100–120 words. [5]

(A) You are Rashmi, a resident of Nayanagar. Write a letter to the Municipal Commissioner, Nayanagar, drawing attention to the problem of open and uncovered drains in your colony. Explain the health and safety hazards caused by the problem and suggest practical measures for its solution.

(B) You are a resident of your locality. Write a letter to the Editor of a national daily expressing concern about poor civic sanitation and the resulting health risks in residential areas. Suggest measures that the civic authorities and residents can take together.

5. Attempt **ANY ONE** of the following two questions, in about 100–120 words. [5]

(A) Write an analytical paragraph comparing **e-learning** and **classroom learning**. Consider accessibility, flexibility, interaction, discipline, cost, infrastructure and the role of the teacher. Conclude by presenting a balanced view of the two modes of learning.

(B) Write an analytical paragraph on the changing role of digital learning in education. Compare its advantages with those of conventional classroom learning and arrive at a reasoned conclusion.

SECTION C – LITERATURE TEXTBOOK

6. Read the following extract carefully and answer the questions that follow. [5]

From *A Letter to God*

Lencho watched the sky anxiously. The clouds that had promised rain soon became a violent storm. Hailstones began to fall, striking the crops and covering the fields. Within a short time the entire harvest was devastated. Looking at the ruined fields, Lencho thought of all the work he and his family had put in—sowing the seeds, tending the plants and watering them. Now he feared that all their labour had been in vain and that they would have no yield that year.

- (i) What weather event had devastated Lencho's crop? [1]
- (ii) Choose the word from the extract that means “*completely destroyed*”. [1]
- (iii) What does Lencho mean when he refers to all the work he and his family had put in? [1]
- (iv) Why would Lencho have preferred a plague of locusts to the hailstorm? [2]

7. Read the following extracts carefully and answer **ANY ONE** of the two extracts given below. [5]

(A) From the poem *For Anne Gregory*

“But I can get a young man's love,
Who will be drawn to my yellow hair;
Yet God, my dear, could love you
For yourself alone.”

- (i) What does the speaker suggest about the young man's attraction towards Anne? [1]
- (ii) What does the phrase “*yellow hair*” represent in the poem? [1]
- (iii) Which word best describes God's love for Anne when it is based on her inner self rather than appearance? [1]
- (iv) Which two ideas are central to the poem?
(1) Physical beauty attracts human beings. (2) Inner beauty is valued by God. (3) Wealth guarantees love.
(4) Human love can be influenced by outward appearance.
(a) 1 and 3 (b) 1 and 4 (c) 2 and 4 (d) 2 and 3 [2]

(B) From the poem *A Tiger in the Zoo*

“He stalks in his vivid stripes
The few steps of his cage,
On pads of velvet quiet,
In his quiet rage.”

- (i) Identify the figure of speech in the expression “*pads of velvet*”. Explain the comparison. [1]
- (ii) What do the words “*quiet*” and “*velvet*” suggest about the tiger's movement? [1]
- (iii) Which option best describes the tiger's mood in the cage?
(a) cheerful and playful (b) subdued and angry (c) careless and relaxed (d) excited and joyful [1]
- (iv) What do the lines about the tiger's stalking and movement reveal about the contrast between his natural instincts and his life in captivity? Answer in 30–40 words. [2]

8. Answer **ANY FOUR** of the following seven questions in 40–50 words each. [12]

- (i) Why did Mandela's hunger for the freedom of his people transform him from a law-abiding citizen into a criminal in the eyes of the apartheid government?
- (ii) How did the dust of snow falling from the hemlock tree change the poet's mood in *Dust of Snow*?
- (iii) What does the postmaster's reaction to Lencho's letter reveal about human kindness and faith?
- (iv) How does the poem *How to Tell Wild Animals* use humour while describing the Bengal tiger and the Asiatic lion?
- (v) What does the young seagull's first successful flight teach us about overcoming fear and gaining confidence?

(vi) How does the poem *The Ball Poem* present the idea of loss and responsibility?

(vii) What is Coorg famous for? Mention the region's natural beauty, people and cultural associations.

9. Answer **ANY TWO** of the following three questions in 40–50 words each. [6]

(i) How does the relationship between Mrs Pumphrey and Tricki highlight the dangers of over-pampering pets?

(ii) How did Griffin's scientific discovery change him from a gifted scientist into a ruthless criminal?

(iii) Why did Hari Singh decide to return to Anil after stealing the money in *The Thief's Story*?

10. Attempt **ANY ONE** of the following two questions in 100–120 words. [6]

(A) Compare Amanda and Valli as two young girls who seek freedom in different ways. How does Amanda's desire for mental freedom differ from Valli's desire for physical freedom and independence?

(B) How does *The Proposal* use humour and conflict to expose the foolishness of social pride, greed and the desire for property? Discuss with suitable references to the characters.

11. Attempt **ANY ONE** of the following two questions in 100–120 words. [6]

(A) How does *The Necklace* present the consequences of vanity and dissatisfaction with one's social position? Explain how the loss of the necklace changes Matilda's life and perspective.

(B) How does *The Midnight Visitor* show that intelligence and presence of mind can be more powerful than physical strength? Discuss how Ausable handles Max.

END OF QUESTION PAPER

Reconstructed to correspond with the supplied answer booklet; wording of the original questions may differ where the answer booklet did not preserve the question text.